



Caribbeans, the Miskitu are an **assimilating** people—they choose partners from a variety of groups, and consider any children to be Miskitu. During the 1800s, Moravian missionaries brought Protestantism to the

people, and this is still the main religion. The origin of the name Miskitu is uncertain. It may have been **inspired** by the English word “musket,” since 17th-century pirates supplied the Miskitu with these weapons.

BUILDING A HOUSE

All Miskitu men know how to build a house, since few women would marry a man without this skill. To protect their families from the region's frequent flooding, they usually build their homes on stilts.



1 Making planks
To prepare the lumber, large pine logs are hoisted up onto a platform. A two-man team then uses a long saw to cut each log into planks.



2 Roofing material
Women gather a special kind of palm leaf called *papta* that is used for thatch. When they get to the site, they will tie it into bundles for the men to work with.



3 Taking shape
At this point in the construction process, the frame is up and work has begun on one of the walls. During the dry season, the roof can safely be left until last.

COOL AND DRY

Miskitu houses allow plenty of cool air to flow underneath, across the open porch, and through the windows. Simple shutters swivel into place when it is cold or rainy.

Traditional buildings have thatched roofs like this one, but some modern homes are roofed with zinc.



PASSING THE TIME

In some communities, unemployment runs as high as 85 percent, partly because only 14 percent of the population have access to secondary education.

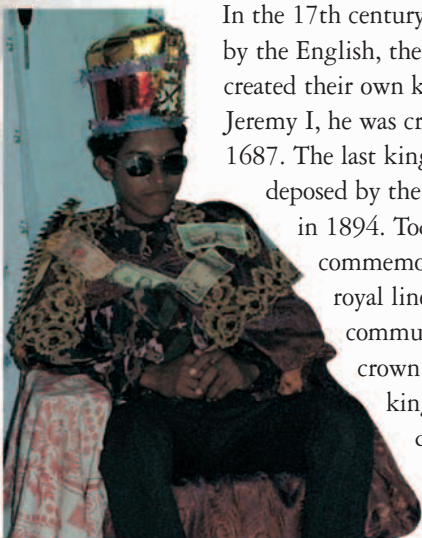


WESTERN INFLUENCE

The culture of the West (especially the US and the English West Indies) has a strong influence on Miskitu life. These boys from the village of Awastara are playing marbles.



CROWNING THE KING



In the 17th century, inspired by the English, the Miskitu created their own king; called Jeremy I, he was crowned in 1687. The last king was deposed by the army in 1894. Today, to commemorate their royal line, many communities crown a symbolic king for one day a year.